

‘MBA IMPORTANT, ITS FORMAT MAY EVOLVE’

M.P. Gupta, Director of IIM Lucknow, on the future of B-schools and why interdisciplinary education is the best way forward

BY **SIDDHARTH ZARABI**

IIM LUCKNOW HAS reinforced its position among India’s leading business schools, ranking third in the *Business Today* ranking of India’s Best Business Schools for 2026-27. The recognition comes at a time management education is being reshaped by changing business models, evolving industry expectations, and the need for future-ready skills. Prof M.P. Gupta, who assumed charge as Director of IIM Lucknow in April 2025, brings decades of experience in higher education, including his association with IIT Delhi, where he served for the last 28 years and has held several administrative positions. In this conversation with *Business Today*, he discusses the changing relevance of MBA, how B-schools must adapt to new corporate realities, the growing importance of technology, multidisciplinary learning, future of placements, and his vision for expanding IIM Lucknow’s role in shaping India’s next generation of business leaders. Edited excerpts:

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What defines excellence in management education today?

If we look at the last 30-40 years, particularly the transition from the pre-internet era, artefacts of corporations have changed significantly. However, the fundamentals have remained the same.

This pertains to understanding customer needsdemand, develop creating products or services as per the needs, , delivering them to an expected quality at competitive prices and ensure ensuring steady positive cash flow. For long-term sustainability and success, businesses also need to build trust among people, systems, processes and customers.

These fundamentals have not changed. What has changed is business models, speed of operations, and the way decisions are made. Disruptive advancements have emerged as the principal catalyst for this change. The internet has had a widespread influence, whereas technologies like artificial intelligence (AI) are generating more targeted upheavals.

As a result, management education needs to adapt at the same speed. Today, creating cutting-edge, pertinent programs with a strong technological component is the key to excellence in management education. It necessitates critical thinking, real-world case studies, outcome-based learning, and classroom environments where students can model business problems and comprehend results.

Internships, mentorship, live projects, and solid industry connections are all equally crucial. Soft skills, particularly emotional intelligence, empathy, cross-cultural understanding, and effective communication, must be prioritized in management education. Additionally, we must be mindful of corporate social responsibility, ethical governance, and sustainability. Ultimately, the biggest differentiator for any institution is its faculty.

India needs to adopt best practices from B-schools globally. We have excellent institutions in India, including the IIMs, but given the challenges of the global environment, we still have a long way to go in strengthening our position on the global map.